

Nation **CONGRESS**

THE CONGRESS
NEEDS TO
REENERGEISE
ITS FRONTAL
ORGANISATIONS;
(BELOW) RAHUL
GANDHI AT
A YOUTH
CONGRESS
CAMP



Front to Back

Rahul Gandhi may have rejuvenated the youth wings but the rest of the frontal organisations of the Congress still lack direction and languish in irrelevance

| By Priya Sahgal |

It was a routine Congress Foundation Day celebration at the party headquarters last year when suddenly Sonia Gandhi beckoned Mahendra Joshi, the Seva Dal chief. She pointed to a couple of workers and said, "They are merely moving their lips, they do not know the words of Vande Mataram." Taken aback, Joshi promised to do the needful during the next Seva Dal training camp.

However, it is not just the words of the national song. A core group of the party's frontal organisation Seva Dal

seems to be forgetting the very *raison d'être* of its existence. Along with the Mahila Congress, the Indian Youth Congress (IYC), the National Students Union of India (NSUI) and the Indian National Trade Union Congress (INTUC), it is supposed to be a feeder channel to the main party. Over time, however, these outfits have deteriorated to mere camp offices. It has taken Rahul Gandhi two years to rejuvenate the youth wings. When the Gandhi scion took over as party general secretary in September 2007, the Youth Congress was a bunch of brash, aimless, not-so-young men. The very same livewire energy that spearheaded so many

agitations under Sanjay Gandhi was now being spent either in acts of hooliganism or in networking deals. Three years ago, a dispirited IYC president Ashok Tanwar, had admitted that the image of networkers and dealers 'plagued' the organisation. Today, the same Tanwar is filled with a sense of purpose. "Earlier when we took a decision we could rarely see it through. We were always pressured by some senior leader to change it. Not so now," he says. Patronage certainly works in the Congress, especially when the mentor

WHEN RAHUL GANDHI TOOK CH